

THE NIGHTMARE KING'S FALSE CHOICE



JULY 27, 2026

I induced lucidity through sleep paralysis and entered the Storyverse aware that I was dreaming.



Below me floated a world of black mirrored cubes, each one glowing red from within and radiating menace.



The King of Nightmares rose behind me, a towering body of burnt vines and thorns crowned by curling branches.



He warned that some nightmares could make sleeping people wander into traffic, fall down stairs, or enter other lethal danger.



Then he called the solution simple: if I truly wanted to save people that night, I had to destroy the entire planet.



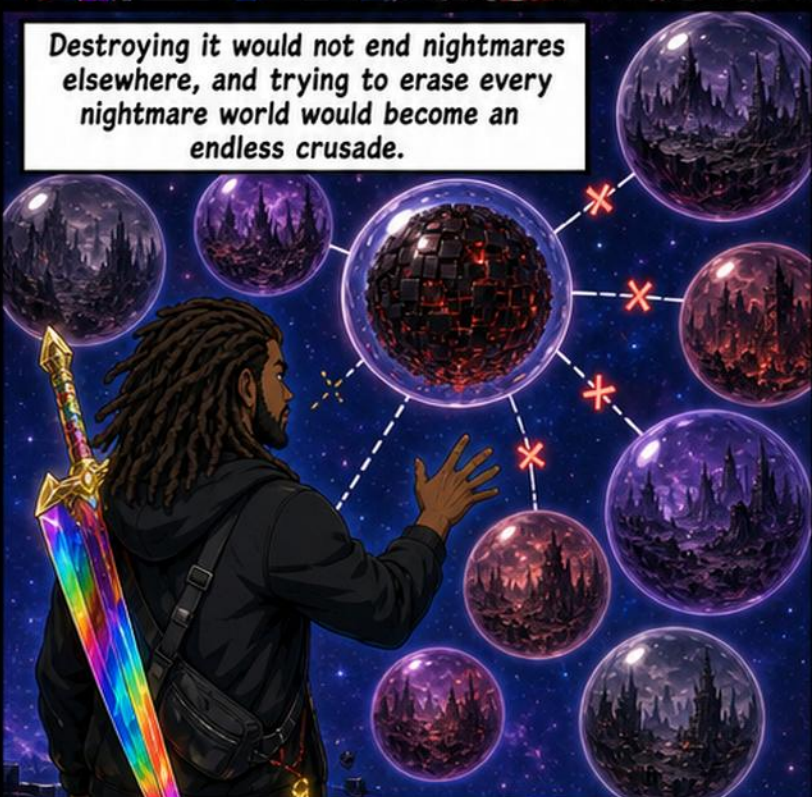
Because I was lucid, I could see the flaw in his mission.



The Storyverse contains infinitely many bubble universes and every possible kind of story. This could only be one nightmare world among countless others.



Destroying it would not end nightmares elsewhere, and trying to erase every nightmare world would become an endless crusade.



The king abandoned logic and turned to guilt.



The King of Nightmares demanded, 'So you're just going to let people die?'



He called me a false hero and tried to make every future nightmare death my responsibility.



Tired of his manipulation, I tested the weakness that seemed most obvious.



Using Lucid Light, I ignited his thorny body with pyrokinetic fire.



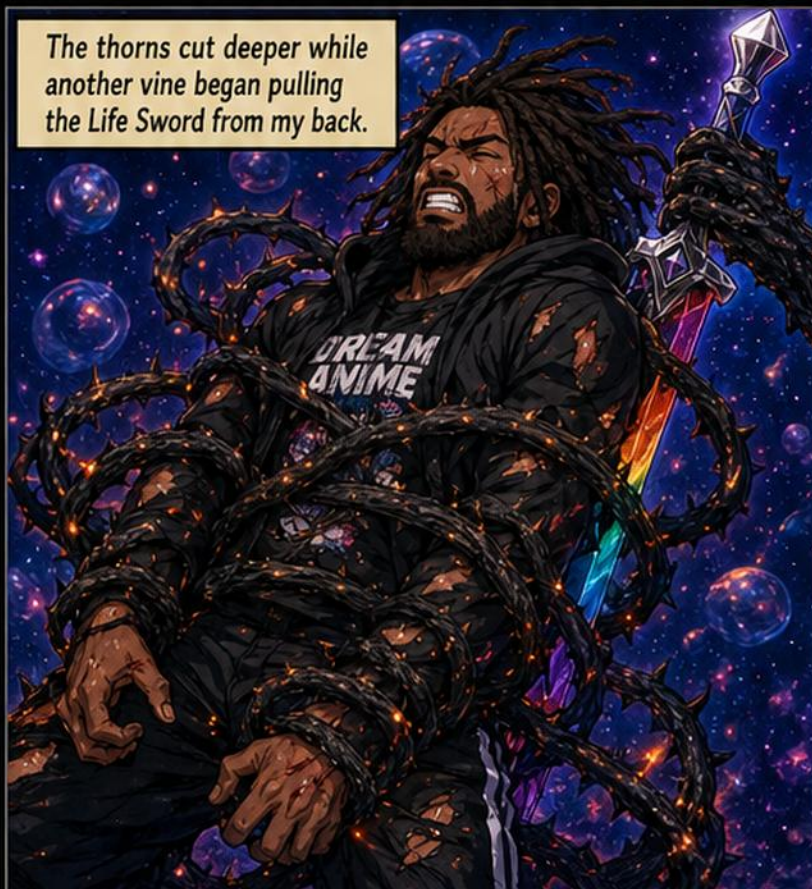
He screamed and thrashed so convincingly that I believed the flames were destroying him.



Then he lunged through the fire and wrapped his burning vines around my body.

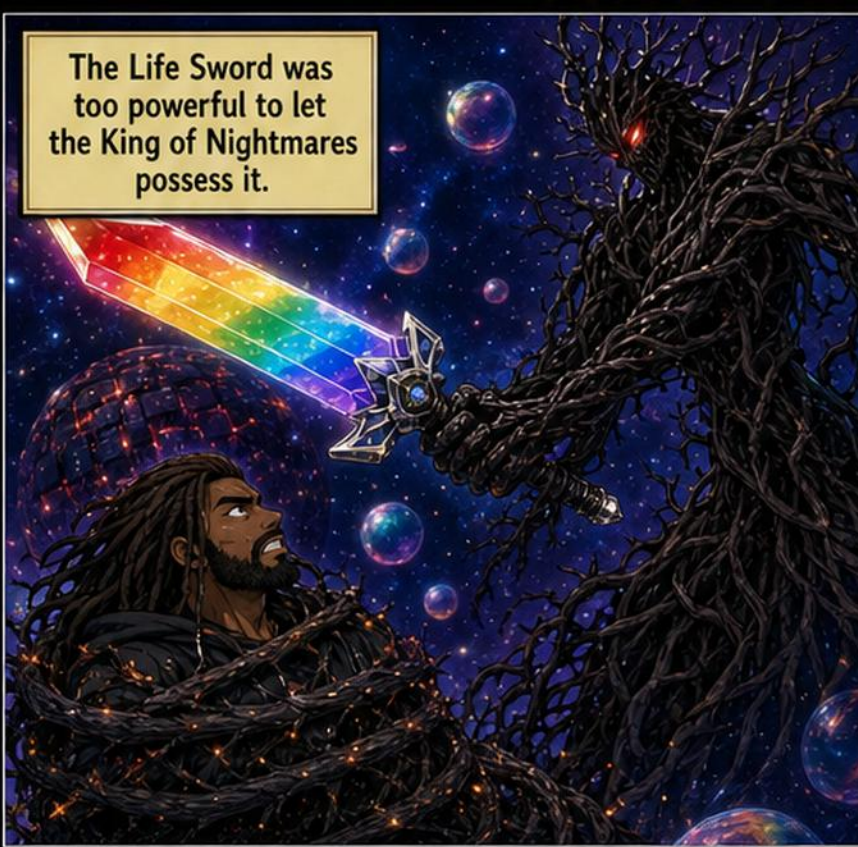


The thorns cut deeper while another vine began pulling the Life Sword from my back.

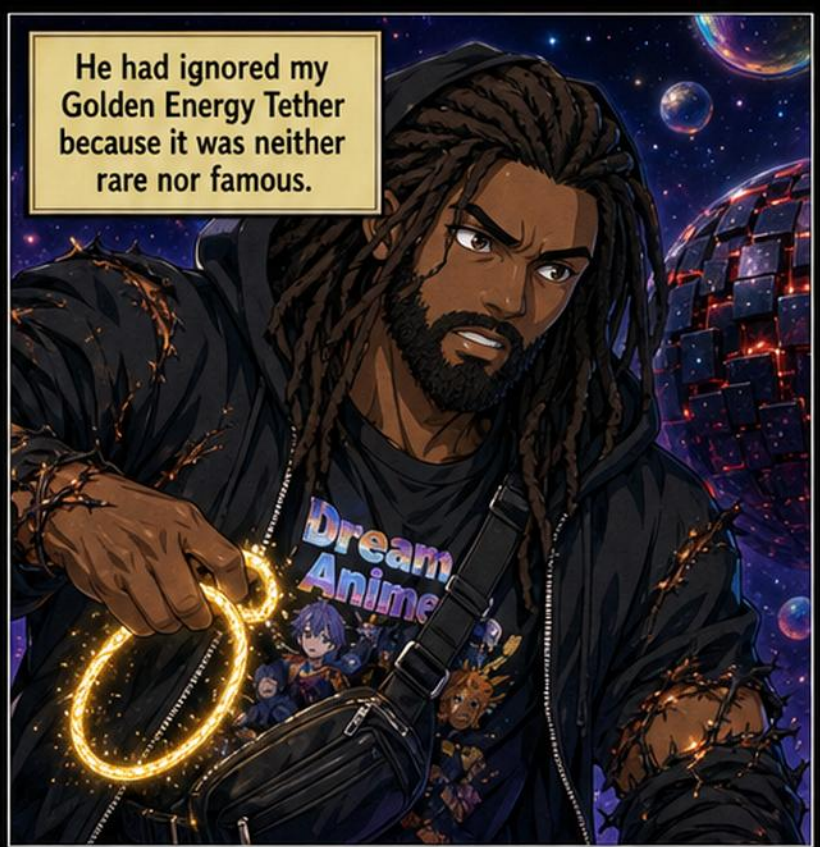


He mocked me: "If fire could destroy me, why would my vines be burnt instead of reduced to ashes?"

The Life Sword was too powerful to let the King of Nightmares possess it.



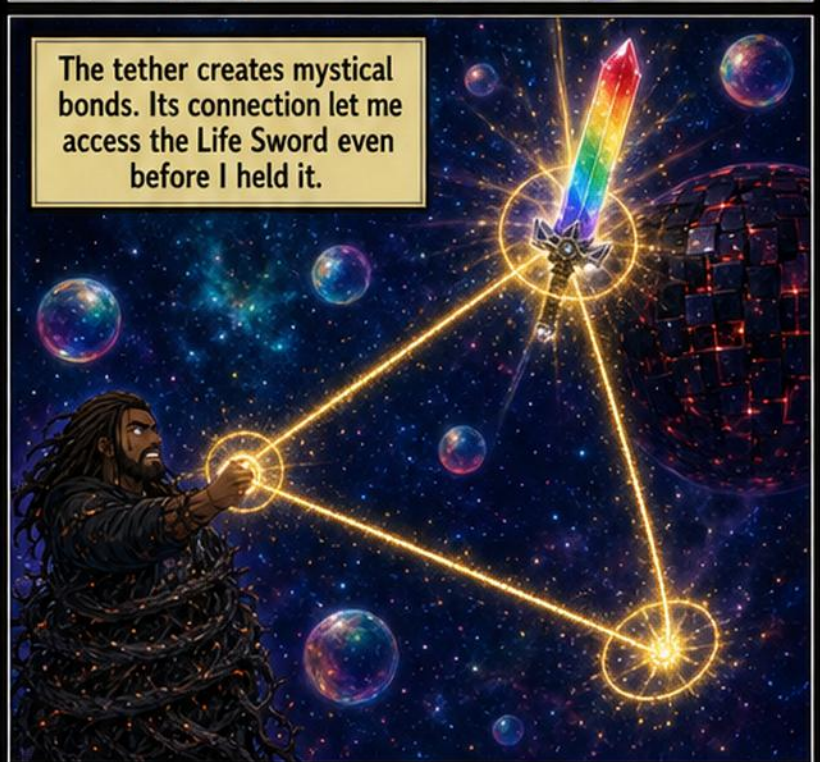
He had ignored my Golden Energy Tether because it was neither rare nor famous.



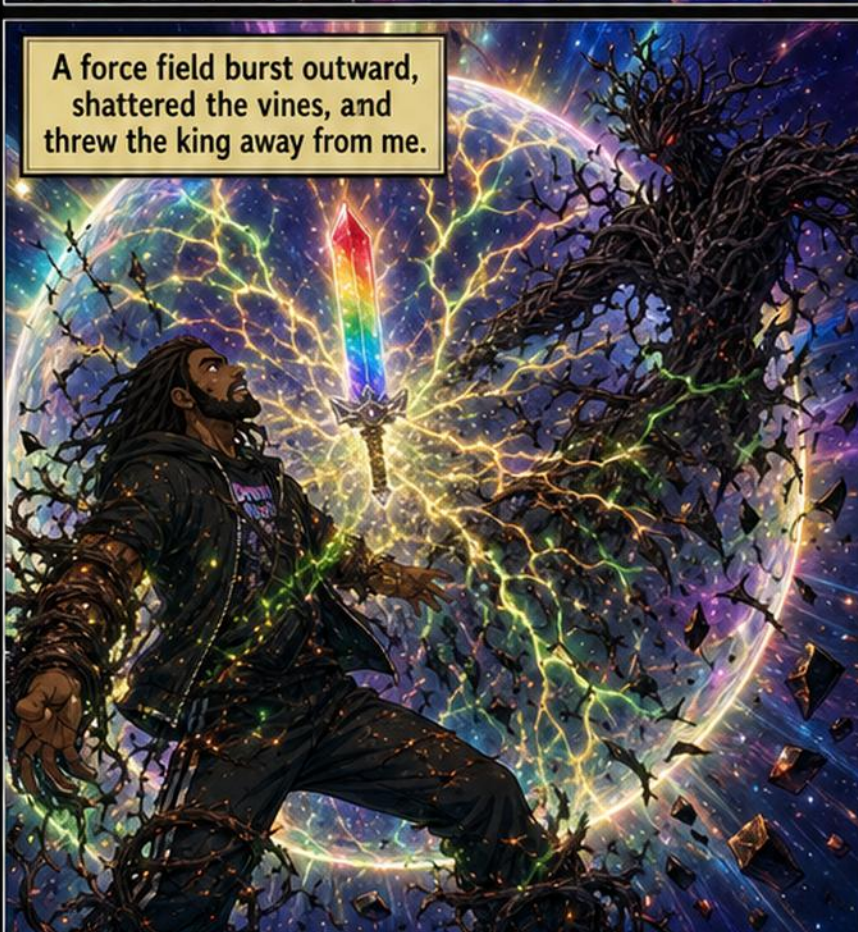
I threw the tether like a lasso and caught the sword before it left my reach.



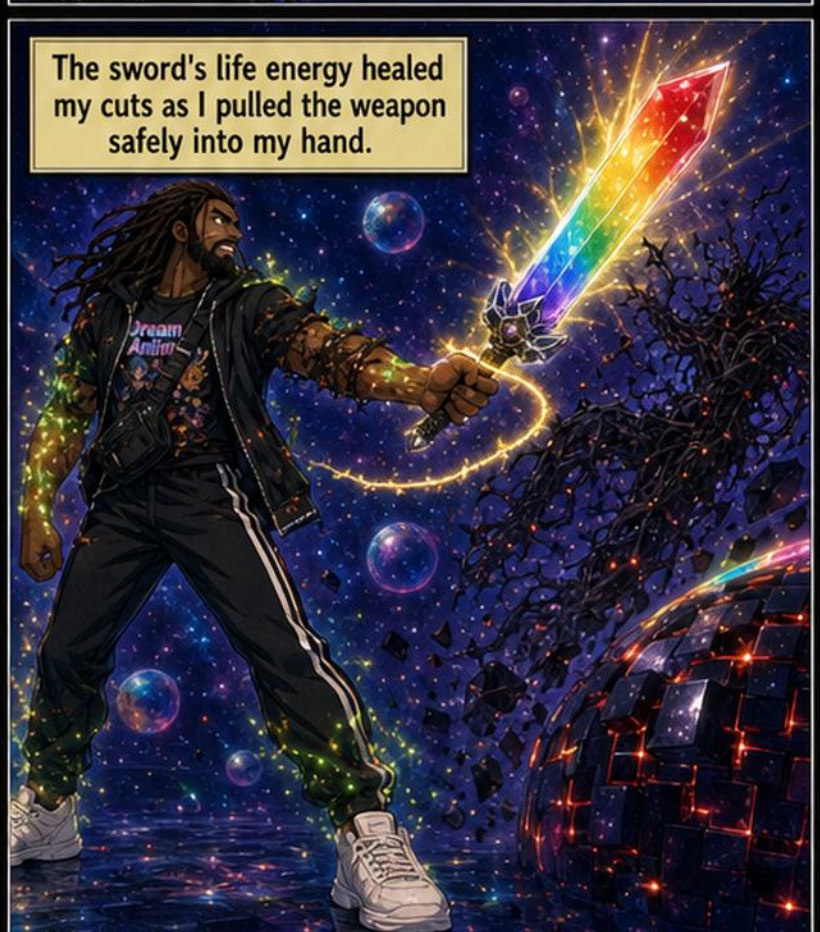
The tether creates mystical bonds. Its connection let me access the Life Sword even before I held it.



A force field burst outward, shattered the vines, and threw the king away from me.



The sword's life energy healed my cuts as I pulled the weapon safely into my hand.



When I raised
the Life Sword
toward the world,
the king believed
he had finally won.



He had never
cared whether
destroying one planet
would end nightmares.



His real goal was
to manipulate a
hero into an atrocity
so extreme that it
would corrupt me
forever.



But destruction
and inaction were
not my only
choices.



Instead of cutting
the planet apart,
I released the Life
Sword's energy as
a force of purification.



Pure life energy washed
across the nightmare world
without burning its
inhabitants to ash.



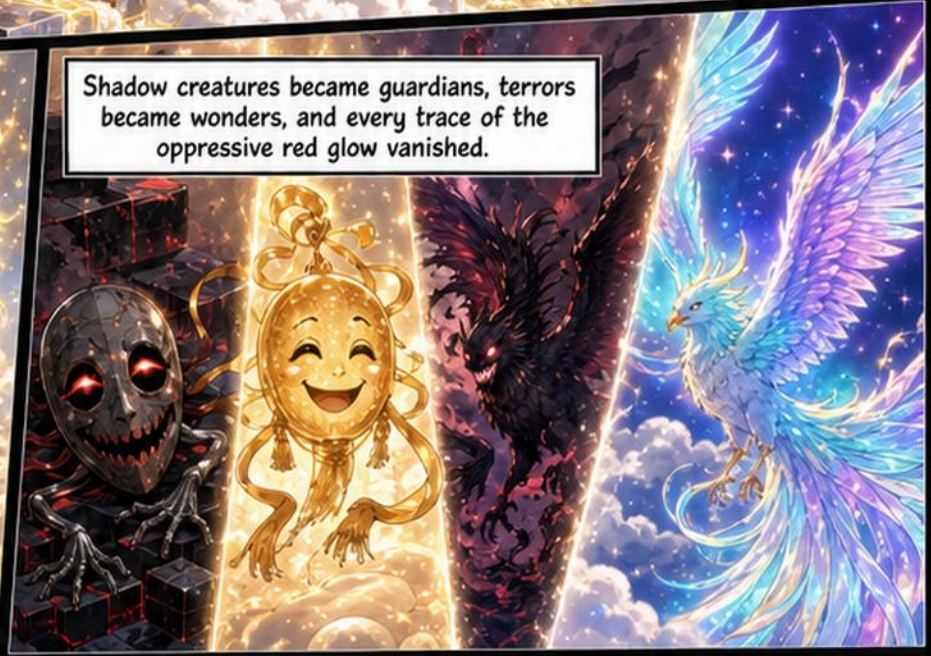
The black mirrored cubes
dissolved into brilliant
white clouds illuminated by
warm golden light.



One by one, the nightmare
beings transformed
instead of dying.



Shadow creatures became guardians, terrors
became wonders, and every trace of the
oppressive red glow vanished.



No longer servants or
victims of the Nightmare
King, the newly liberated
dreams rose from their
transformed world.



They gathered around me
and chose to fight beside me.



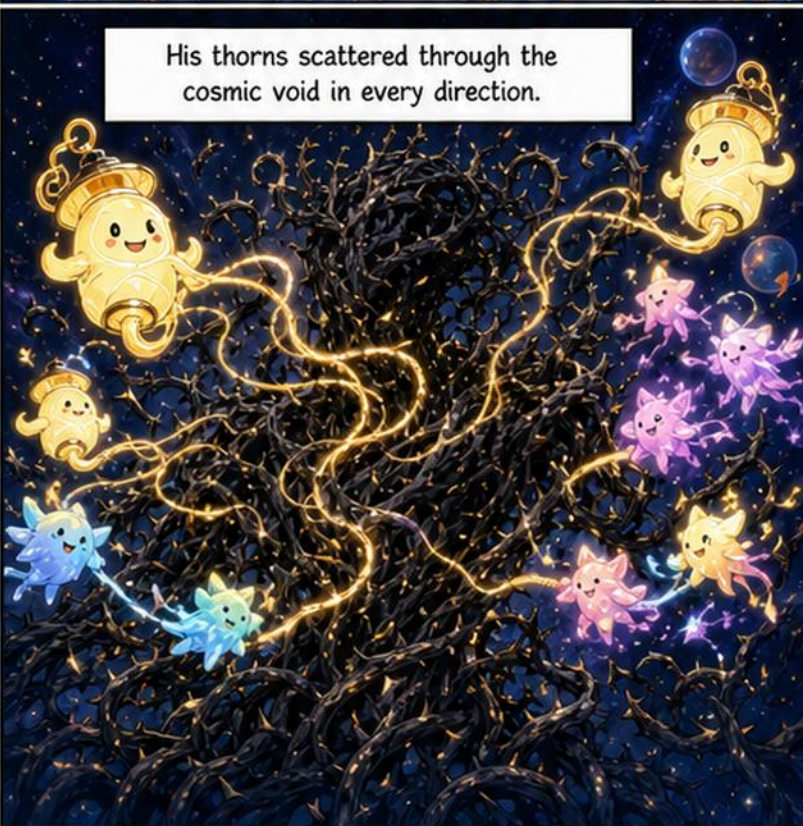
Together, the dreams overwhelmed the being who had ruled them through fear.



They dismantled his crown, arms, and body until no twisted mass of burnt vines remained.



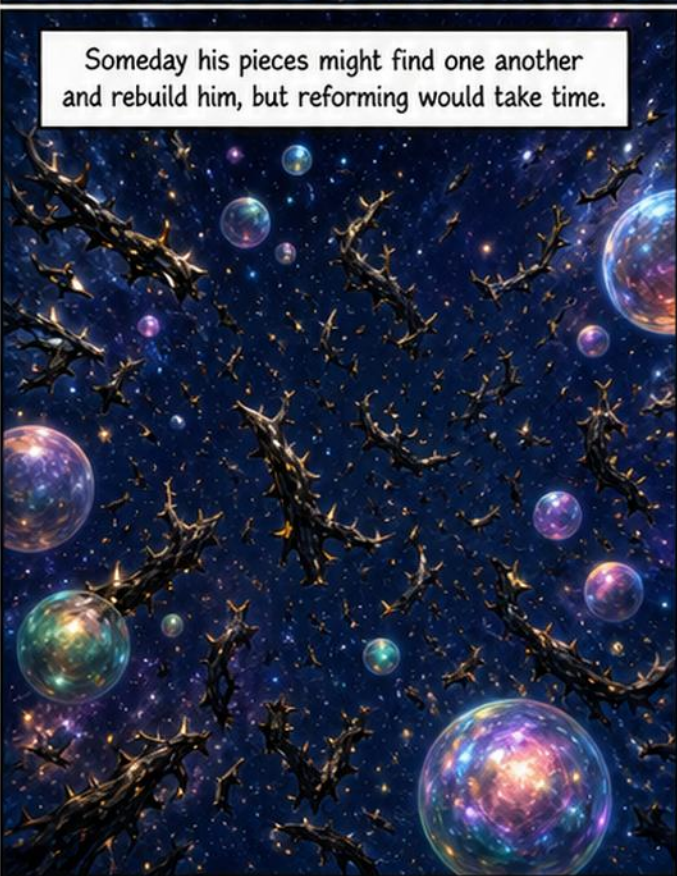
His thorns scattered through the cosmic void in every direction.



The King of Nightmares was an archetypal being, so this was probably not his permanent end.



Someday his pieces might find one another and rebuild him, but reforming would take time.



Every moment he remained scattered gave dreams and their defenders more time to protect people and keep doing what was right.

